

Talk to me, sensibly



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PRL PCME...and so on. 'Parents are listening, please call me later' for the initiated. For the rest, it's plain gibberish. SMS is sprouting up a whole new language. The hearing impaired, for instance, find it very handy. The text is short and understood even by those not used to the English language. And since most mobiles can be set on the vibrator mode, the hearing impaired get alerted when there's a message.

There are no boundaries to the development of this language. It will never stop, given its popularity and usage. There are no grammar or spelling rules and there is no such thing as a mistake. There are only suggestions. You can use letters or numbers to

valuable exam tips. SMS is undoubtedly a great asset.

But there are problems too. There's a danger of the means to an end becoming an end in itself if not used in moderation. SMS is being misused by terrorist groups. We all are spammed by chain messages. And now there are also reports that the standard of written English is getting sloppy among students due to the overwhelming popularity of SMS. Students in Singapore have been increasingly using SMS-style English in their class assignments. For instance, some students now spell the word 'before' as 'b4', 'night' as 'nite' and 'with' as 'wif'. Teachers are concerned that the efforts to promote the use of good English are 'being undone by SMS'.

Now SMS is the 'n thing', but shouldn't we observe a language protocol? To get to the Net, you have to follow TCP/IP—a protocol. Real life rules are no different. Like, would you ever strut into a discotheque in a formal suit? Or would you walk in for an interview with a bank in half pants? Obviously not! You will feel out of place or made to feel unwanted. It makes tremendous sense to send a quick SMS to your friend. He understands your lingo so your acronyms gel with him. But try sending your resume in SMS, especially if you're applying for a copydesk or writer's position (you will be surprised that employers do get such resumes). Your resume will be in the trash can. Your potential employer will be grr and you will be :-(

The issue is not about whether the English language gets corrupted or not. The US changed the rules of the game with their spellings. Language has to keep on evolving but all communication has a purpose—to be understood. What's the point of sending an SMS in an abbreviated form if the other person does not understand the message? Besides, there is the hsp (highly sensitive person) who might take offence. So the next time you SMS, make sure the language is tailored to suit your audience. If the SMS lingo becomes the dominant language, you can have the LL (last laugh). Till then, FTR and hand (follow the rules and have a nice day). ■

// **Would you ever strut into a discotheque in a formal suit? Or would you walk in for an interview with a bank in half pants?** //

complete words or instead of words—u = you, l8r = later, 4 = for. The idea is to make words as short as possible—wd = would, mor = more, etc.

Now there are over 11 million cellular subscribers in India. In all probability, you and I use a cellphone. And all of us do use the SMS facility extensively. SMS has become so popular among executives, housewives and youngsters alike, that 18 lakh SMS messages have been recorded between major cellular phone operators every day.

About 3 lakh SMS were sent and more than 22,000 customers dialled and registered for news alerts as soon as they heard about Warne renouncing 'cricket's greatest show on earth'. Acknowledging the fact that text messaging is one of the most popular methods of communication among youngsters, group SMS is being used in some schools abroad to give the students some